# Northeast Tennessee K-12 Finance Trends

*Per-pupil expenditures across 13 districts, 2018-19 through 2024-25*

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## Executive Summary

This report tracks K-12 per-pupil expenditures across the 13 public school systems of Northeast Tennessee from 2018-19 through 2024-25, the years for which TDOE Report Card finance files are publicly available. It is a companion to the regional enrollment trends study published earlier this month. Where the enrollment study showed a region shrinking by roughly 11% over a decade, this finance study shows a region whose per-pupil spending is rising fast — up 37.4% in six years, well above general inflation. The combination is the central story for NE TN school finance: fewer students, but more dollars per student, with widening differences in how that money is funded.

## Headline numbers

**Regional weighted per-pupil expenditures, 2018-19 to 2024-25:**

• 2018-19: $9,765 | 2024-25: $13,415

• Six-year change: +$3,650 per pupil (+37.4%)

• Compound annual growth rate: +5.4%/yr

• U.S. CPI over the same period rose roughly 22%, so real per-pupil spending grew ~12%.

• Total regional spending: $634M → $849M (+33.9%) on a slightly smaller student count.

**Key district-level findings:**

• Every district except Johnson County saw double-digit per-pupil spending growth.

• Hancock County (+55%) and Washington County (+54%) led the region in PPE growth.

• Greeneville City rose from $11,122 to $15,266 (+37.3%, tied for fifth in the region).

• Greene County rose from $9,062 to $12,531 (+38.3%) and remains in the bottom third regionally.

• Cities now average $14,079/pupil; counties $12,998/pupil. The city-county gap persists.

• Johnson County is an outlier: per-pupil expenditure appears to fall, but that's an artifact of TN Connections Academy (a statewide virtual school) inflating the enrollment denominator.

## Methodology and data sources

Data: TDOE Report Card per-pupil expenditure files for school years 2018-19 through 2024-25, retrieved from tn.gov/education/data/data-downloads. Seven Excel files in total. Each file reports school-level and district-level expenditures broken down by federal, state-and-local, and school nutrition sources, plus combined totals.

Geography: same 13 NE TN public school systems used in the enrollment trends report — Bristol, Carter County, Elizabethton City, Greeneville City, Greene County, Hancock County, Hawkins County, Johnson County, Johnson City, Kingsport City, Sullivan County, Unicoi County, and Washington County.

Schema differences across years: the 2018-19, 2019-20, 2021-22, 2022-23, 2023-24, and 2024-25 files share a near-identical schema with school-level and district-level per-pupil expenditures broken out by funding source. The 2020-21 file ("per-pupil-expenditures-fy21-updated-2023-02-17.xlsx") was republished by TDOE in February 2023 with values that match 2021-22 almost exactly at the school level. It appears to be a republishing artifact and is excluded from time-series calculations to avoid double-counting that period; the underlying numbers are still archived in the workbook.

Definition of "enrollment" in the Report Card files: TDOE uses the all-grades enrollment count, including pre-K and statewide virtual school students, to compute per-pupil amounts. This differs from the K-12 resident enrollment figures reported in the companion enrollment study. The PPE figures here are reported on TDOE's denominator so they match the published Report Card.

Caveat — Johnson County: TN Connections Academy is a statewide virtual school enrolled administratively through Johnson County. Its students show up in Johnson County's enrollment denominator (~3,000 of ~4,800), which mechanically depresses Johnson County's per-pupil expenditure number. Johnson County's finance figures should not be directly compared to other NE TN districts in this report.

Caveat — salary breakdowns: the federal and state/local salary-vs-non-personnel detail is only populated at the district aggregate level for 2020-21 and 2021-22 in TDOE's published files. Charts using that breakdown reflect the most recent year available (2021-22).

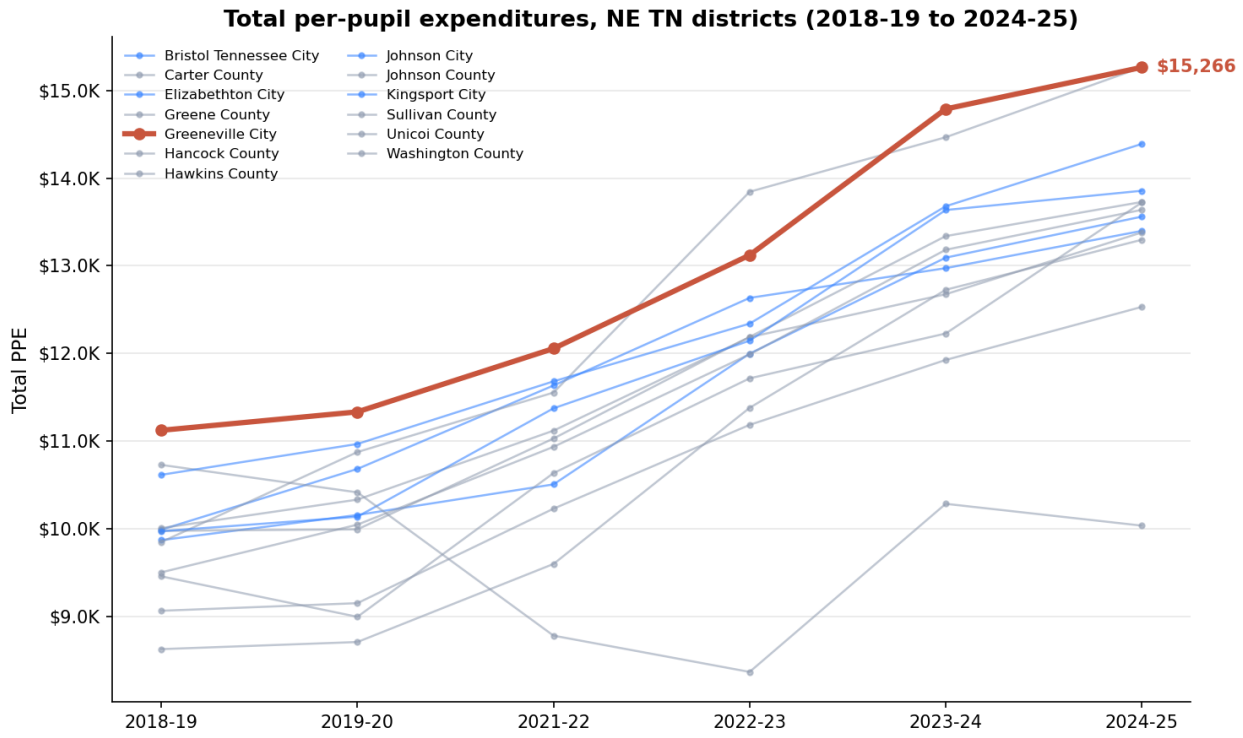
## Regional Totals: How the Money Has Grown

Across the 13 NE TN districts, total spending rose from $634M in 2018-19 to $849M in 2024-25, an increase of $215M (+33.9%). On a per-pupil basis, the picture is starker: weighted PPE rose from $9,765 to $13,415, an increase of $3,650/pupil (+37.4%). Per-pupil grew faster than total spending because regional enrollment slipped from ~64,900 to ~63,300 over the same window.

Compounded over six years, the +5.4%/yr CAGR exceeds general U.S. inflation (CPI was ~22% cumulative from 2018 to 2024, or roughly 3.4%/yr). Real per-pupil spending rose roughly 12% net of CPI.

| Year | NE TN Enrollment | Total Spending | Weighted PPE |
|---|---|---|---|
| **2018-19** | 64,894 | $633.7M | $9,765 |
| **2019-20** | 64,741 | $639.9M | $9,884 |

| | | | |
|---|---|---|---|
| **2021-22** | 62,418 | $675.6M | $10,824 |
| **2022-23** | 65,290 | $766.8M | $11,744 |
| **2023-24** | 63,994 | $822.4M | $12,851 |
| **2024-25** | 63,251 | $848.5M | $13,415 |



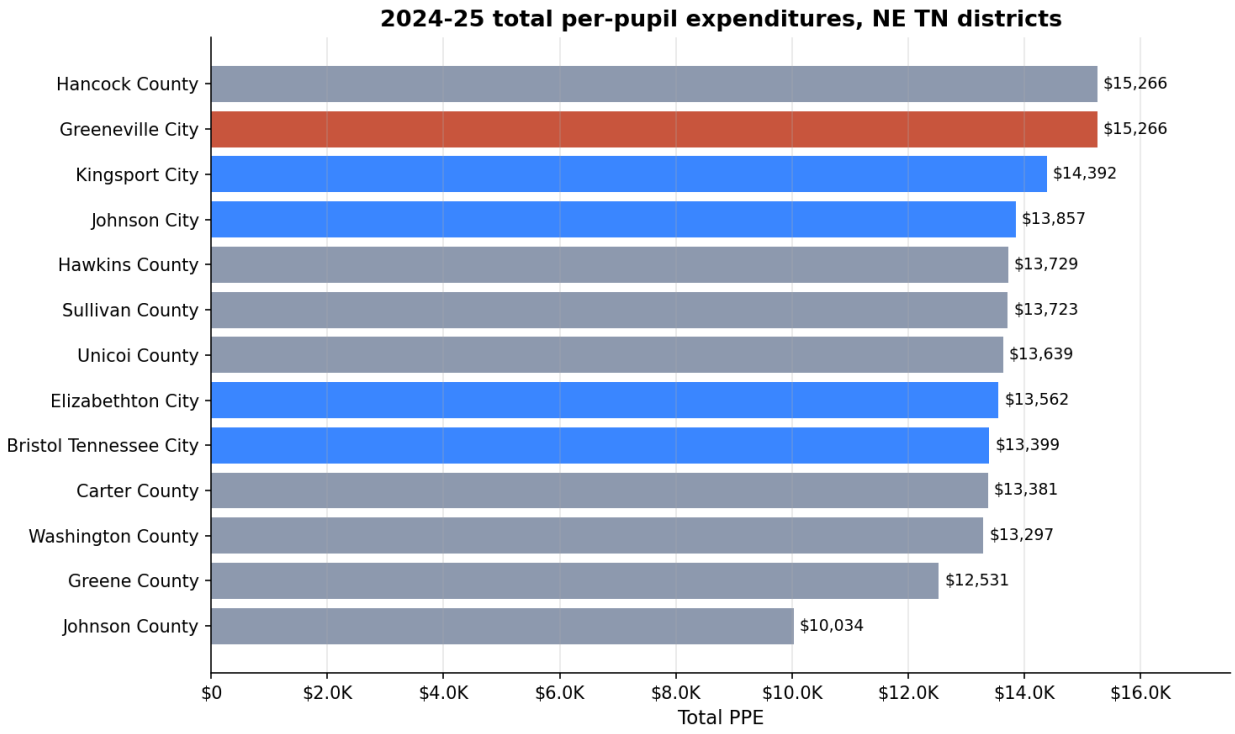

*Total per-pupil expenditures by district. Greeneville City highlighted in red. City systems blue, county systems gray.*

## District Rankings: 2024-25

Greeneville City and Hancock County tie for the highest per-pupil expenditure in the region at roughly $15,266. Hancock's number is heavily weighted toward federal and state funding (66.9% state, 12.0% local), while Greeneville's is funded much more locally (40.0% local, 50.9% state). Johnson County is an outlier (caveat noted above). Of the rest, Greene County and Washington County sit at the lower end of the regional PPE spectrum.

| Rank | District | Enrollment | Total PPE |
|---|---|---|---|
| **1** | Hancock County | 842 | $15,266 |
| **2** | Greeneville City | 2,860 | $15,266 |
| **3** | Kingsport City | 7,392 | $14,392 |
| **4** | Johnson City | 7,623 | $13,857 |
| **5** | Hawkins County | 5,913 | $13,729 |
| **6** | Sullivan County | 7,667 | $13,723 |
| **7** | Unicoi County | 1,942 | $13,639 |
| **8** | Elizabethton City | 2,573 | $13,562 |
| **9** | Bristol Tennessee City | 3,928 | $13,399 |

| | | | |
|---|---|---|---|
| **10** | Carter County | 4,133 | $13,381 |
| **11** | Washington County | 7,832 | $13,297 |
| **12** | Greene County | 5,731 | $12,531 |
| **13** | Johnson County | 4,815 | $10,034 |

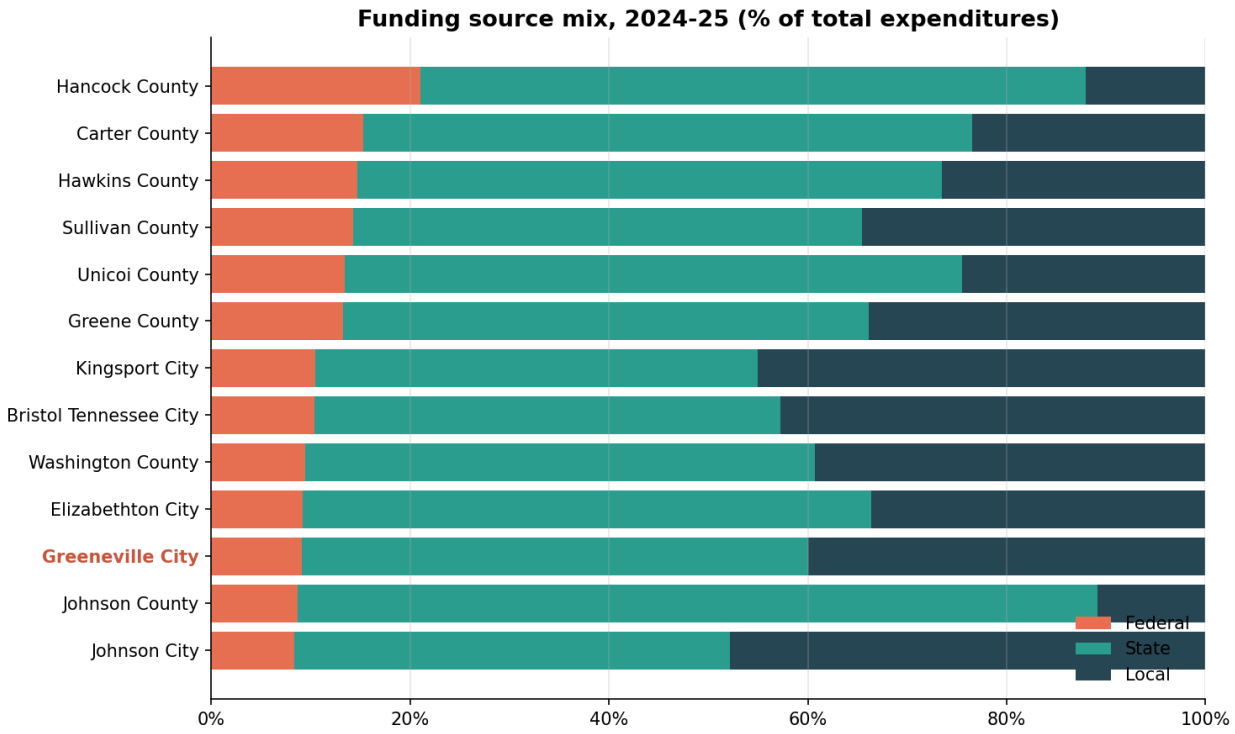



*2024-25 total per-pupil expenditures, NE TN.*

## Funding Mix: Where the Dollars Come From

TDOE reports federal, state, and local funding shares for each district. In 2024-25, those shares vary widely across NE TN. Urban systems with strong commercial property tax bases (Johnson City, Kingsport, Bristol) draw 43-48% of their funding locally. Mid-sized districts (Greeneville, Washington County, Sullivan, Greene County) sit in the 34-40% local range. Rural and small-tax-base counties (Carter, Hawkins, Unicoi) are in the 23-27% local range, with Hancock County at 12% local — the lowest in the region.

Federal share also varies meaningfully. Hancock County's federal share is 21%, the highest in NE TN, reflecting its heavy reliance on Title I and free-and-reduced-lunch-driven federal allocations. Most districts sit in the 9-15% federal range.



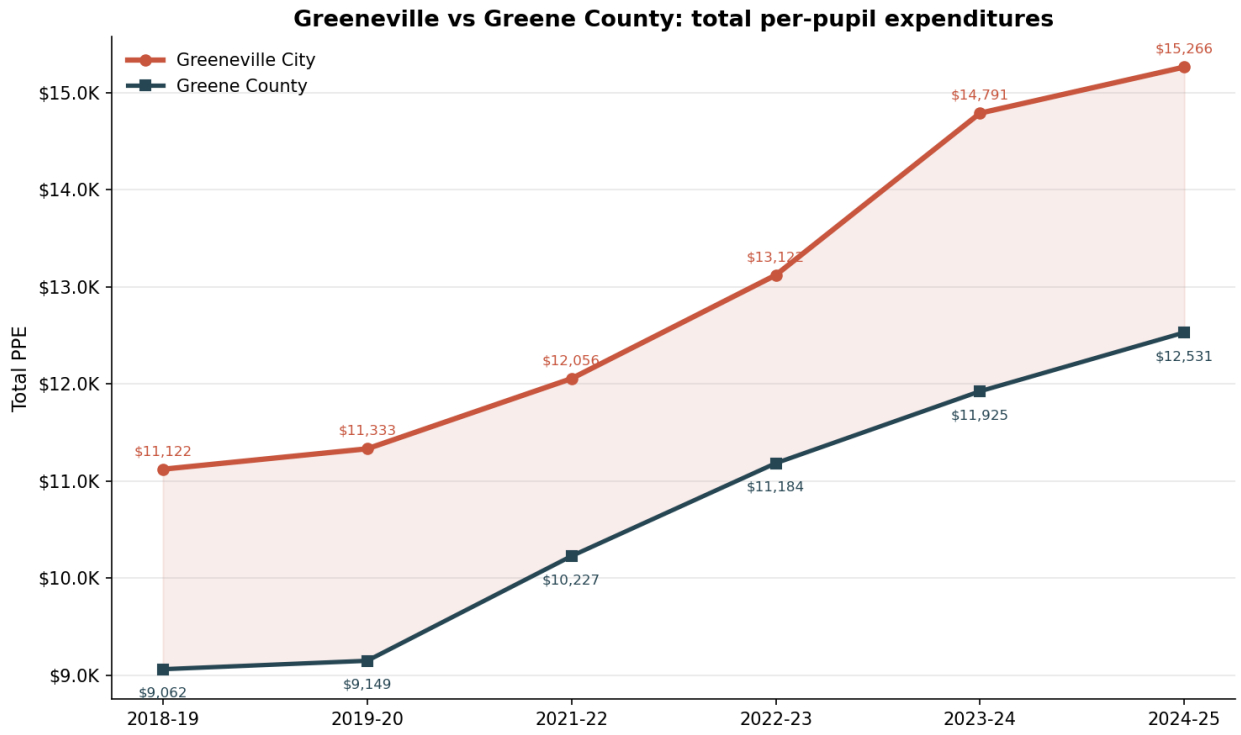

*Federal/state/local share of total expenditures, 2024-25. Sorted by local share.*

| District | Federal % | State % | Local % |
|---|---|---|---|
| **Johnson City** | 8.3% | 43.8% | 47.8% |
| **Kingsport City** | 10.5% | 44.5% | 45.0% |
| **Bristol Tennessee City** | 10.4% | 46.9% | 42.7% |
| **Greeneville City** | 9.1% | 50.9% | 40.0% |
| **Washington County** | 9.5% | 51.3% | 39.3% |
| **Sullivan County** | 14.2% | 51.2% | 34.6% |
| **Greene County** | 13.3% | 52.8% | 33.9% |
| **Elizabethton City** | 9.2% | 57.2% | 33.6% |
| **Hawkins County** | 14.7% | 58.9% | 26.5% |
| **Unicoi County** | 13.4% | 62.1% | 24.4% |
| **Carter County** | 15.3% | 61.3% | 23.4% |
| **Hancock County** | 21.0% | 66.9% | 12.0% |
| **Johnson County** | 8.7% | 80.5% | 10.8% |

## Greeneville City vs. Greene County

The two systems serving the Greene County footprint sit roughly $2,700 apart in per-pupil expenditures. Greeneville City spent $15,266/pupil in 2024-25; Greene County spent $12,531. The gap has widened: it was $2,060 in 2018-19 and $2,735 in 2024-25. Both systems grew per-pupil spending at similar rates over the period (Greeneville +37.3%, Greene County +38.3%), so the widening gap is dollar-driven rather than growth-rate-driven.

On funding mix, Greeneville City pulls 40.0% of its funding locally compared to Greene County's 33.9%. Both systems are well above the regional county average for local share, reflecting Greeneville's commercial tax base and the city-county shared revenue model.




*Greeneville City vs. Greene County total per-pupil expenditures.*

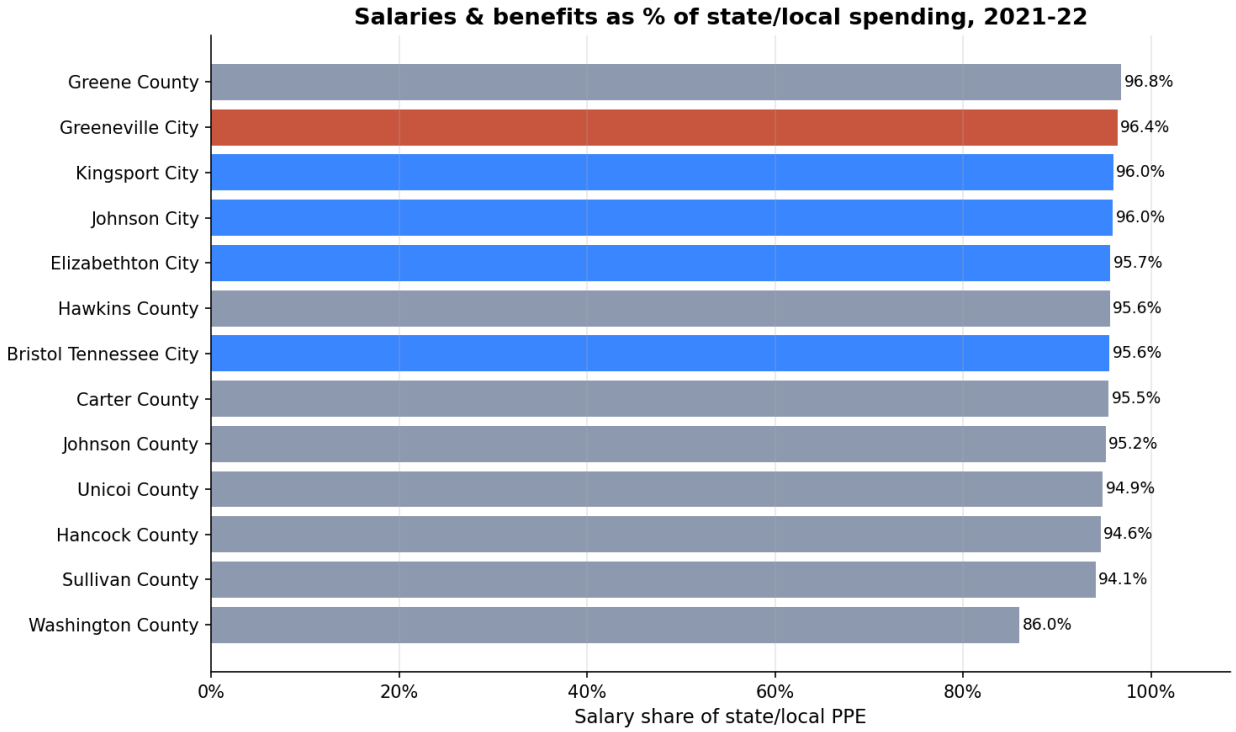
## City Systems vs. County Systems

City systems consistently outspend county systems in NE TN, both in absolute per-pupil dollars and in growth rate. In 2024-25, the five city systems (Bristol, Elizabethton, Greeneville, Johnson City, Kingsport) averaged $14,079/pupil on a weighted basis. The eight county systems averaged $12,998 — a gap of $1,081/pupil, or about 8%.

The divide tracks closely with local revenue capacity. City systems serve denser, higher-property-value footprints with stronger commercial tax bases. They tend to fund more of their total expenditures locally, which gives them more discretion over teacher salaries, classroom resources, and supplemental programs.

## Salary and Personnel Share

The most recent year for which TDOE published salary-vs-non-personnel detail at the district aggregate level is 2021-22. In that year, salaries and benefits averaged 89-95% of state-and-local spending across NE TN districts. There is little variation across systems on this metric — most NE TN districts spend 90%+ of their state and local dollars on personnel.



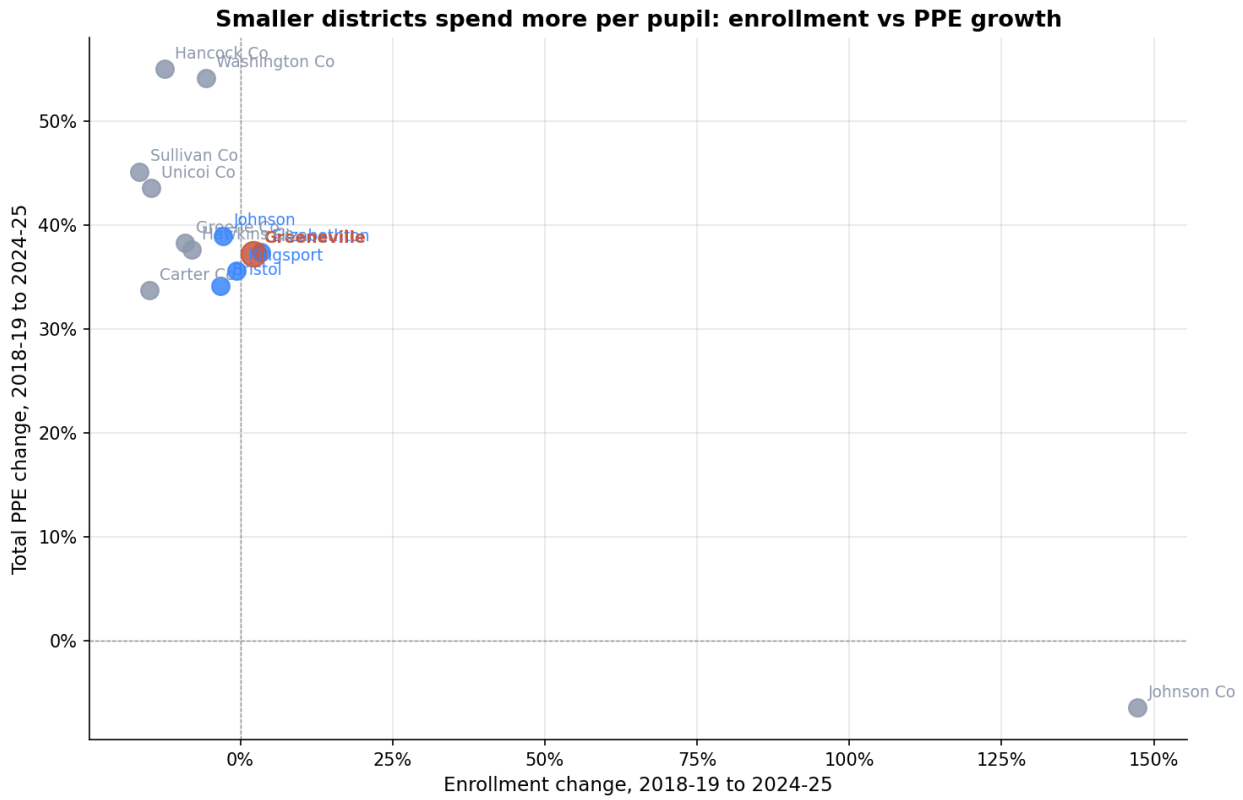

*Salaries and benefits as share of state/local spending, 2021-22. (Most recent year with district-level breakdown published.)*

## Enrollment vs. Spending: A Hard Equation

Pairing this finance data with the regional enrollment trends shows the structural challenge clearly. Per-pupil spending is rising in every district except Johnson County (a data artifact). Total spending is also rising in most districts. But enrollment is falling in 11 of 13 systems.

The math: a smaller denominator with growing total dollars produces fast PPE growth. That's good news for current students but a fiscal warning sign for districts. Fixed costs (utilities, buildings, administration, transportation routes) don't shrink in proportion to enrollment, so PPE growth in shrinking districts is partly real investment and partly the math of carrying fixed overhead across fewer kids.

Greeneville City is a relative bright spot — flat enrollment paired with PPE growth that's roughly in the middle of the regional pack. Greene County, Sullivan County, and Carter County are in the harder position: enrollment loss alongside PPE growth that's near the regional average, meaning their total spending is climbing faster than their student count would suggest is sustainable.




*Enrollment change vs. PPE change, 2018-19 to 2024-25. (Enrollment uses TDOE's all-grades count, including PK and statewide virtual.)*

## District-Level Change, 2018-19 to 2024-25

| District | 2018-19 PPE | 2024-25 PPE | $ change | % change | CAGR |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| **Hancock County** | $9,847 | $15,266 | $+5,419 | +55.0% | +7.6% |
| **Washington County** | $8,624 | $13,297 | $+4,673 | +54.2% | +7.5% |
| **Sullivan County** | $9,455 | $13,723 | $+4,268 | +45.1% | +6.4% |
| **Unicoi County** | $9,501 | $13,639 | $+4,139 | +43.6% | +6.2% |
| **Johnson City** | $9,970 | $13,857 | $+3,887 | +39.0% | +5.6% |
| **Greene County** | $9,062 | $12,531 | $+3,469 | +38.3% | +5.6% |
| **Hawkins County** | $9,974 | $13,729 | $+3,755 | +37.6% | +5.5% |
| **Elizabethton City** | $9,869 | $13,562 | $+3,693 | +37.4% | +5.4% |
| **Greeneville City** | $11,122 | $15,266 | $+4,144 | +37.3% | +5.4% |
| **Kingsport City** | $10,614 | $14,392 | $+3,778 | +35.6% | +5.2% |
| **Bristol Tennessee City** | $9,987 | $13,399 | $+3,411 | +34.2% | +5.0% |
| **Carter County** | $10,006 | $13,381 | $+3,375 | +33.7% | +5.0% |
| **Johnson County** | $10,727 | $10,034 | $-694 | -6.5% | -1.1% |

## What This Means for NE TN

Three things stand out from this analysis:

1. PPE growth across NE TN is real but mostly inflationary. After adjusting for the ~22% cumulative CPI increase over 2018-2024, the region's real per-pupil growth is closer to 12%. That's still meaningful, but it's not the 37% nominal headline. The underlying drivers are state salary supplements (BEP/TISA increases), federal stimulus rolling off after FY24, and rising operational costs in transportation, food service, and benefits.

2. The funding mix divides the region into three groups. Urban districts with strong commercial tax bases (Johnson City, Kingsport, Bristol) fund 43-48% locally. Mid-sized systems (Greeneville, Washington Co, Sullivan Co, Greene Co) fund 34-40% locally. Rural counties (Carter, Hawkins, Unicoi, Hancock) fall to 12-27% locally and rely heavily on state and federal sources. Local-share differences drive most of the variation in total PPE.

3. The combination of enrollment decline and PPE growth puts a long-term fiscal squeeze on shrinking districts. Greeneville City is partially insulated by stable enrollment; Greene County, Sullivan County, and Carter County are not. The TISA student-based funding formula will increasingly reward stable or growing enrollments and penalize systems that cannot grow.

## Follow-up Questions Worth Pursuing

• Pull the TDOE Annual Statistical Report Section 4 to extend the finance picture back another decade (pre-2018-19). The data structure differs (revenues + expenditures by function code) but would let us see whether the 2018-2024 PPE growth rate is exceptional or simply continuation of a longer-running trend.

• Reconcile this PPE data with TISA Step 1/Step 2/Step 3 weighted ADM allocations to see how much of the rising local share is property-tax growth vs. fee growth vs. capital outlay. The Greeneville WFTEADA tracker is useful here.

• Cross-reference with the chronic absenteeism data and graduation outcomes — does higher PPE correlate with better student outcomes in NE TN, or are we spending more without the corresponding lift?

• Track ESSER tail-off: federal share peaked in 2021-22 for many districts. The 2024-25 federal share gives a clean baseline of post-stimulus federal funding levels.

## Data Sources and Files

• TDOE Report Card per-pupil expenditure files, 2018-19 through 2024-25 — tn.gov/education/data/data-downloads

• Companion enrollment dataset: NE TN K-12 Enrollment Trends, 2015-16 to 2024-25 (April 2026)

• Inflation context: U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics, CPI-U

*Cleaned datasets, raw files, and the companion .xlsx workbook live in:*

*~/Documents/Research/NE-TN-Finance-Trends/*